

Softer Than Water: Close Reading Laozi's Tao Teh King

An original lesson plan inspired by **Laozi (trans. James Legge)**'s *The Tao Teh King, or the Tao and its Characteristics* (Project Gutenberg). Not affiliated with or endorsed by Project Gutenberg or Laozi (trans. James Legge). Explore the original course: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/216>

GRADE LEVEL

Grades 9-12

DURATION

50 minutes

TOPICS

Eastern Philosophy

“Laozi describes water as the softest thing in the world, yet able to wear away the hardest stone — what could this image teach us about strength, and about how to act well in the world?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Read and paraphrase, in their own words, several core chapters of the Tao Teh King in James Legge's translation (chapters 1, 2, 8, and 78).
- Identify recurring paradoxes in the text — the Dao that cannot be named, the mutual dependence of opposites, softness overcoming hardness — and explain what each paradox is meant to teach.
- Apply the water metaphor and the idea of wu-wei (effortless, unforced action) to construct an original short parable illustrating 'the soft overcoming the hard.'

Materials Needed

- Printed excerpts of Legge's translation of chapters 1, 2, 8, and 78
- Whiteboard for the opposites-brainstorm activity
- Blank index cards or paper for the parable-writing activity

Lesson Procedure

Hook: Can Opposites Need Each Other?

8 min

Ask students: can you have 'up' without 'down,' or 'easy' without knowing what 'hard' feels like? Brainstorm a list of paired opposites on the board (long/short, loud/quiet, before/after). Ask whether each pair could exist meaningfully alone, or whether each side actually depends on the other for its meaning. This previews chapter 2's claim that opposites arise together and define each other.

Close Reading: Chapters 1 and 2

14 min

Read chapter 1 aloud together (the Dao that can be spoken is not the eternal Dao) and discuss what it might mean for something to be real and important but resistant to being fully captured in words. Then read chapter 2's list of paired opposites (being and non-being, difficult and easy, long and short) arising from one another, connecting it back to the hook activity, and noting that this is offered as a reason the wise person acts without excessive striving or claiming credit.

Close Reading: Chapters 8 and 78

15 min

Read chapter 8's comparison of the highest good to water, which benefits all things without contending with them and is content to occupy low places others avoid, then chapter 78's claim that nothing in the world is softer or weaker than water, yet nothing surpasses it at overcoming the hard and strong. In pairs, students identify what specific quality of water (yielding, going low, persistence) the text seems to be praising, and discuss whether this quality is really a form of strength or simply a poetic reframing of weakness.

Parable-Writing Activity

9 min

Individually or in pairs, students write a very short original parable (4-6 sentences) set in the modern world that illustrates 'the soft overcoming the hard,' modeled on the water image but using a different scenario of their own choosing (a conversation, a sport, a friendship, a workplace).

Closure: Share and Reflect

4 min

Invite 2-3 volunteers to read their parables aloud. Close by returning to the essential question and asking for a quick show of hands: do students find the water metaphor a genuinely convincing model of strength, or mostly a nice-sounding image?

Discussion Questions

- 1 If opposites like 'difficult' and 'easy' truly depend on each other to have meaning, does that change how you think about wanting only the 'good' half of any pair (only ease, only success) without its opposite?
- 2 Is 'being like water' — yielding, going low, avoiding contention — actually a realistic strategy for handling conflict in your own life, or does it only work in the kind of patient, long-timescale examples the text describes (water eroding stone)?
- 3 The text says the Dao that can be spoken is not the eternal Dao — does that mean reading and discussing this text in class is somehow the wrong way to engage with it, or can words still point toward something they can't fully capture?
- 4 Chapter 8 praises occupying 'low places that others disdain' — is this genuine humility, or could it also be read as a strategic way to avoid competition and conflict altogether?
- 5 Can you think of a real situation, historical or personal, where a soft, patient, non-confrontational approach actually outperformed a harder, more forceful one?

Assessment

Students submit their original parable illustrating 'the soft overcoming the hard,' along with a short paragraph explaining which specific chapter or image from the Tao Teh King inspired it and how their parable adapts that image to a modern scenario.

Extension Activity

Have students find one modern proverb, saying, or piece of advice (from any culture) that expresses a similar idea to chapter 78's water image — that gentleness, patience, or yielding can overcome force — and write a short comparison of the two, noting any differences in emphasis or context.

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